



MARSEILLE FRANCE

Fishy Feast in the South of France

Marseille may not be pretty in a traditional Provençal way, but France's oldest city is not short of appeal. Marseille's charm lies in its multicultural, Mediterranean vibe, charismatic scruffiness, and that most famous of all Marseille dishes, bouillabaisse – a rich, briny boil-up of the morning's catch fresh from the port, fragrant, silky, and golden-glistening in the luminous sunshine.



Bouillabaisse was originally a fishermen's stew – the unsold catch of, usually, the smallest and most unprepossessing fish, cooked up in a pot of

bubbling water on the beach. Today it is a more sumptuous dish, enriched with butter and saffron, much more in keeping with the recipe's origins in legend – concocted by Venus to lull her husband Vulcan to sleep so she could have some fun with Mars. Lots of variations exist in Provence, but Marseille lays claim to the best: a jamboree of local fish and shellfish, olive oil, onions, garlic, fennel, tomatoes, potatoes, parsley, and the golden ingredient, saffron. The city even has an official Charter of Bouillabaisse listing the ingredients that “must” be used in the dish, including a minimum of four fish from a choice of red mullet, John Dory, *rascasse* (scorpion fish), monkfish, and conger eel.

Small, bony rockfish and *rascasse* provide the base for the broth, which is reduced and concentrated – the word bouillabaisse probably derives from *bouille abaisse*, or “boil and reduce” – until it's as pungent as Davy Jones' locker. The soup is served first, bobbing with, traditionally, a single large crouton daubed with garlicky *rouille* – a ruddy mayonnaise spiked with

chili pepper – followed separately by a heaped platter of fish that have been simmered in the broth.

The fish is landed daily at the Vieux Port (old port), where fishermen have been selling their catch for 350 years. Marseille today may be a huge, modern city – multi-ethnic, soccer-crazy, and with one of the most hair-raising traffic systems in France – but it's rich in history, as vibrant and eclectic as its signature dish. Not for nothing was it voted European Capital of Culture 2013. Painted by Cézanne, Renoir, and Dufy, it is the home of the Château d'If, where Alexandre Dumas's *Count of Monte Cristo* was imprisoned, and of architect Le Corbusier's seminal Unité d'Habitation.

Rising up behind the Vieux Port, Le Panier is the oldest part of the city, a hub of narrow streets and steps with pale candy-colored houses and a cosmopolitan mood thanks to decades of immigration. Nearby is the souk-like Marché des Capucins, a North African-flavored market piled with exotic produce and pastries. On the other side of the harbor, surveying the designer hotels, lounge bars, galleries, and boutiques that have sprung up below, sits Marseille's “Good Mother” – the magnificent Byzantine church of Notre Dame de la Garde, keeping watch over a city that gave France one of its most classic recipes.

A Day in Marseille

A modern city whose 26 centuries of cultural heritage and, at its heart, a fishing village atmosphere, come together to make Marseille a compelling destination.

MORNING Set off from **Fort Saint-Jean** and meander the winding streets of **Le Panier**, stopping to check out local archaeological finds at **La Vieille Charité**. Once a poorhouse, it's now crammed with priceless ancient artifacts. Drop into Marseille's answer to Istanbul's Hagia Sophia, the huge **Cathédrale de la Major**.

AFTERNOON Contrast old and new at **La Joliette** docks, where the Euroméditerranée Project is making bold architectural statements, including the shimmering 485-ft (148-m) **CMA-CGM Tower** designed by Zaha Hadid. If fashion is more your passion, peruse the collection of 20th-century clothes and accessories in the **Musée de la Mode**.

EVENING Climb up to **Notre Dame de la Garde** to take in a sweeping, 360° city view. Meander back to the **Vieux Port**, grab a seat on the terrace of a quayside bar, order a tall pastis, and watch the sun fade before dinner.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Shuttle buses and taxis run from Marseille's **international airport** to the city. **Trains** link to most of France and beyond, with **bus** services to Provençal towns, including Nice.

WHERE TO STAY

Hôtel Le Corbusier (inexpensive): perfect for 1950s design fans. www.hotelcorbusier.com
Casa Honoré (moderate): a tiny boutique hotel steps from the Old Port. www.casahonore.com
Le Petit-Nice Passédat (expensive): a fabulous family-run villa. www.petitnice-passeadat.com

TOURIST INFORMATION

www.marseille-tourisme.com

